

Chapter 93_1 - Getting Closer

If the former Chu Qingqiu was like clouds in the sky, then now she was like mist on earth. The former was untouchable and unreachable, while the latter could be touched, yet one dared not touch her, as if one touch would make her scatter with the wind and never return.

Although Ning Fuyi was very reluctant, she didn't hold her for too long before letting go and placing her hands behind her back.

Su Mo realized she had lost her composure. She lowered her head and wiped away her tears several times. When she raised her eyes again, only a patch of red remained at the corners, like peach blossoms falling into snow—poignant and distinct.

She raised her hand to gesture: "Sorry."

Although Ning Fuyi couldn't sign yet, after a night of forced memorization, she could understand simple sign language. So she nodded and reached out to pick up the water buckets from the ground, but was stopped by Su Mo.

Her gaze fell on Ning Fuyi's still-bleeding hand. She gestured for her to wait here, then her green robes swayed as she ran back to the house and brought out medicinal paste stored in a bamboo tube.

The paste was black, quite a large tube—clearly something she had made for her own use.

She indicated for Ning Fuyi to spread out her hand, then used her fingertip to apply the slightly bitter-smelling medicine, carefully coating the cut area.

When Ning Fuyi first entered the demon cave, she had fought many bloody battles. Such a wound now would heal in a snap of her fingers, but she remained motionless, watching the woman's serious expression as she applied the medicine, and her distinct black hair in the morning light.

In her heart, she felt fortunate—fortunate that she hadn't approached rashly. With Su Mo being so heavily guarded, if she hadn't used the excuse of being injured to move in, she probably wouldn't have been able to get close to her at all.

"A year of good scenery you must remember, precisely when paths meet clear autumn¹." Ning Fuyi suddenly said. "Can I call you Qing Qiu² in the future?"

She didn't know many poems by heart, only a few about clear autumn that she still remembered.

Su Mo's hand applying the medicine paused, then she shook her head.

Alright, Ning Fuyi felt somewhat dejected: "Fine then, I'll call you Su Mo."

Su Mo worked quickly and had already finished applying the medicinal paste. She wiped away the remaining blood with a handkerchief, efficiently put away the bamboo tube, and gestured again.

"Don't call me anything. You're only staying here for two days, then you leave immediately."

After "saying" this, she turned to pick up the water buckets again. Ning Fuyi wanted to help, but Su Mo turned away to avoid her: "Since you're injured, don't move around."

Ning Fuyi didn't dare force anything on her anymore. She could only watch helplessly as Su Mo swayed unsteadily while carrying the water buckets, following the continuous green fields toward the river.

Her figure became smaller and smaller, finally turning into a small green dot on the wooden bridge. The distant mountain mist rose like cooking smoke, the blue water rippled with waves, and the sparkling light reflected the morning glow like a poem or painting.

Ning Fuyi sighed, watching Su Mo's return journey with full water buckets being even more arduous. She had to stop and rest every few steps, then continue walking through gritted teeth after resting enough, making the short distance extraordinarily long.

Finally, Ning Fuyi couldn't bear to watch anymore. She raised her hand and cast a Lightness Spell³ to help reduce the weight a little, but didn't dare go too far lest Su Mo notice, then walked back into the house.

This version of Su Mo was really too difficult to warm up to. She didn't know Su Mo's past, didn't trust her origins, and feared that after two days she would really be driven away.

If it really came to that, maybe she should just build a nest nearby and be a neighbor, Ning Fuyi thought as she tapped her hand on the table.

She was lost in thought when she suddenly heard the sound of pots and pans clashing. She leaned to the side and hid behind the window to look, seeing Su Mo's figure busy at the simple stove.

Her movements were very nimble, as if she was in a hurry to do something. Soon she brought out a plate and a bowl and walked to Ning Fuyi's door.

Ning Fuyi quickly pulled the door open.

The brownish-gray clay bowl contained porridge—though calling it porridge, it was really no different from rice soup. The water in the bowl was almost clear; if you stirred it with chopsticks, you could turn up some overcooked rice from the bottom.

The plate looked much fuller, filled with some kind of wild vegetables from the mountain, with no meat in sight.

Su Mo placed this kind of breakfast on the table and gestured: "I only have these things here. They can't compare to the food in town."

Ning Fuyi was stunned for a moment, then reached out to take the bowl and chopsticks, saying thanks.

Seeing that Su Mo was about to leave, she hurriedly stopped her: "Aren't you eating?"

"I already ate." Su Mo gestured, then lowered her eyes, turned around, and closed the door.

Ning Fuyi's hand gripping the bowl tightened, but not because these meager provisions were too sparse. Rather, she was thinking—before she came, had Su Mo lived on such food for over twenty years?

No wonder when she held Su Mo's hand earlier, their five fingers could actually interlock.

A surge of melancholy rose in Ning Fuyi's heart. This melancholy pressed against her heart and lungs with an indescribable sourness and stuffiness. So she silently put down the bowl and chopsticks and began eating with her head down.

The wild vegetables were bitter and astringent, and the porridge was like drinking water, but she still finished everything. Then she took the bowl and plate to the stove to wash them with water.

She happened to see Su Mo shouldering yesterday's huge basket, opening the fence gate and preparing to go out.

Ning Fuyi wanted to grab her and ask where she was going, but remembering how she had frightened her earlier, she didn't approach rashly again. She just watched Su Mo walk toward the distant mountains, then lowered her head to wash the bowls and chopsticks clean, placing them on the clean but rotting rack beside the stove.

Another bowl was still sitting on the stove. Ning Fuyi picked it up to throw into the water for washing, but caught sight of wild vegetable remnants inside.

The bitter wild vegetables had been eaten completely clean. There were no other bowls besides this one. Ning Fuyi's nose suddenly stung.

Although Su Mo was guarded and cold toward her, she had still brought the only bowl of porridge into Ning Fuyi's room.

Ning Fuyi dabbed at the corner of her eye with her sleeve, lowered her head to wash the bowl clean, then looked around the kitchen for any other chores to do. However, everything was tidy and sparse. She opened the rice jar—only a thin layer of white rice remained at the bottom. She couldn't even find any flour, and the basket in the corner contained some unknown wild vegetables and herbs.

Besides these, there was nothing left.

Ning Fuyi closed her eyes, turned and walked into the rising sunlight, then cast an invisibility spell and headed in the direction Su Mo had left.

Su Mo walked very slowly carrying the large basket. Ning Fuyi caught up to her in a short while. The woman's thin figure headed straight into the mountains. At first there was still a narrow path trodden by hunters underfoot, but as they went deeper into the mountains, the path disappeared, leaving only scattered rocks and weeds.

Su Mo didn't stop either, but supported herself on the thick trees on either side as she climbed up with difficulty. Although it was cool in the forest, she soon broke out in a sweat on her forehead.

Being unable to hear or call out like this, yet still venturing into the forest daily, she had actually managed to survive until now. Ning Fuyi bit her lip and followed from a distance, her expression becoming increasingly complex.

Su Mo ahead suddenly stepped on something, her foot slipped and she fell sideways. Ning Fuyi quickly shot out a stream of air, pressing down a nearby sapling so it fell within Su Mo's reach. Su Mo stumbled and grabbed the sapling, avoiding a fall to the ground.

Ning Fuyi broke out in a cold sweat watching this and wiped her forehead, breathing a sigh of relief.

Su Mo's mountain trip was quite busy. She seemed very familiar with the medicinal herbs in the ground. Her small hoe would strike the earth twice and she could pull up an herb to toss into her basket.

When she encountered herbs that weren't so good, she would lower her head to smell them and sigh before putting them in her personal pouch.

She was extremely serious throughout, rolling up her sleeves and revealing arms pale from rarely seeing sunlight. When they occasionally got dirty with soil, it was very noticeable.

She worked for a whole day, and Ning Fuyi followed behind watching her for the whole day. Except for resting under the tree shade for the time of one incense stick when the noon sun was too harsh, eating a few wild fruits, she never rested again.

When the forest light grew sparse and the sun slanted westward, she finally shouldered her basket full of medicinal herbs and wild vegetables down the mountain. When the path under her feet finally became level, Ning Fuyi quietly transformed into points of light and headed to town.

She bought lots of rice, flour, chickens, ducks, vegetables and fruits from town, stuffing them all into bundles to bring back to the bamboo house. Because she flew the whole way, she was much faster than Su Mo. After placing everything under the stove, Su Mo finally returned home wearily, bent over with her basket.

Ning Fuyi quickly ran over and reached out to lift down the heavy basket, helping her place it behind the house.

Su Mo glanced at Ning Fuyi. This time she at least didn't object, lowering her head to silently cover the basket with grass mats.

"Are you tired?" Ning Fuyi said, pinching her sleeves. She pointed toward under the stove. "I went to town today and bought some food, thinking to repay you for taking me in."

But when Su Mo saw those things, her brows knitted together and her eyes became colder than usual. She raised her hands, which had many more scratches, and refused: "Su Mo is just a poor citizen. I only lent you a grass hut to sleep in and cannot accept such great thanks. Please take these things away, young lady."

She turned toward the stove and ignored the items on the ground, instead picking up wild vegetables from the bamboo basket to steam and cook with a whooshing sound.

Originally filled with enthusiasm, Ning Fuyi was rebuffed and felt somewhat defeated. She stood in place watching Su Mo prepare another meal without any meat, then watched Su Mo walk around her into the small house.

"Miss Su Mo, I can't just sleep in your house for nothing. This room is fine for me to sleep in." She tried to speak again.

She was met with the creaking sound of the door closing firmly.

Footnotes:

¹ **"A year of good scenery you must remember, precisely when paths meet clear autumn"** (一年好景君须记，恰是陌上清秋时): A variation of a famous line from Su Shi's poetry, with "Mo" (paths) referencing Su Mo's name and "Qing Qiu" meaning "clear autumn."

² **Qing Qiu** (清秋): Meaning "clear autumn," referencing Chu Qingqiu's original name.

³ **Lightness Spell** (飘然诀): A magical technique to reduce weight and make objects easier to carry.